



The Pampas

Wide, flat grasslands stretching across the southeastern corner of South America, forming some of the richest grazing land in the world

South America's huge expanse of grassland known as pampas extends from the foothills of the Andes east to the Atlantic coast. Because *pampa* means "flat surface," the term is used for many smaller plains all over the continent, but the largest and most well known is the Argentine Pampas.

Covering around 295,000 square miles (760,000 square km), the Pampas consists mainly of a flat, unbroken plain that slopes gently from an elevation of 1,640 ft (500 m) in the northwest to just 65 ft (20 m) in the southeast. This expanse of land can be divided climatically into two main sections. The larger western dry zone of central Argentina is dominated by coarse grass species such as stipa and is dotted with marshes. The smaller, more fertile, but heavily populated humid zone in the east features a combination of grassland and dry woodland. While much of the Pampas' original coarse grass has been replaced with grass species more suitable to domestic livestock that have grazed here for two centuries, the region remains a vital habitat for endangered species such as the Pampas deer and the Argentine tortoise.



▷ STEALTHY MOVEMENT

Geoffroy's cat is a small, efficient, and opportunistic predator, hunting throughout the Pampas for rodents, reptiles, birds, and fish.

Few trees can survive the frequent **wildfires** of the Pampas, but **grasses** regenerate easily

△ FEATHERY TUFTS

Pampas grass reaches heights of up to 12 ft (3.6 m) or more. The featherlike flower heads hold up to 100,000 seeds each.

▷ HIGH VIEWPOINT

Standing 5 ft (1.5 m) tall, the greater rhea cannot fly, but it can run as fast as 37 mph (60 kph). It is often seen grazing with herds of Pampas deer.

